CE was not tied to a growth in adherence to Buddhism per se, but rather to a pivotal recrafting of political alliances in the region. After the defeat of the Hephthalites at the battle of Gol-Zarriun (mid-sixth century) primarily at the hands of the "Chinese" or Western Turks, the ever-present Sasanian *shahanshah*s eventually allied with the latter in order to maintain some control of their eastern territories. Aside from this new regional power structure, however, it remains unclear whether the previously dominant Hephthalites were completely displaced, or still present in regional pockets. The interrelated dynasties of Kabul and Zabul – the latter being the Rutbils of the early Arabic sources (see Chapter 2, and below) – and the Shar of Bamiyan all pledged loyalty to the *Yabghu* presiding over the Western Turks' territories south of the Oxus. But it is debated whether the local rulers were themselves Western Turk or Hephthalite, and whether they relied for regional administration upon a newly created echelon of Turks, or a lingering Hephthalite "aristocracy."[39]

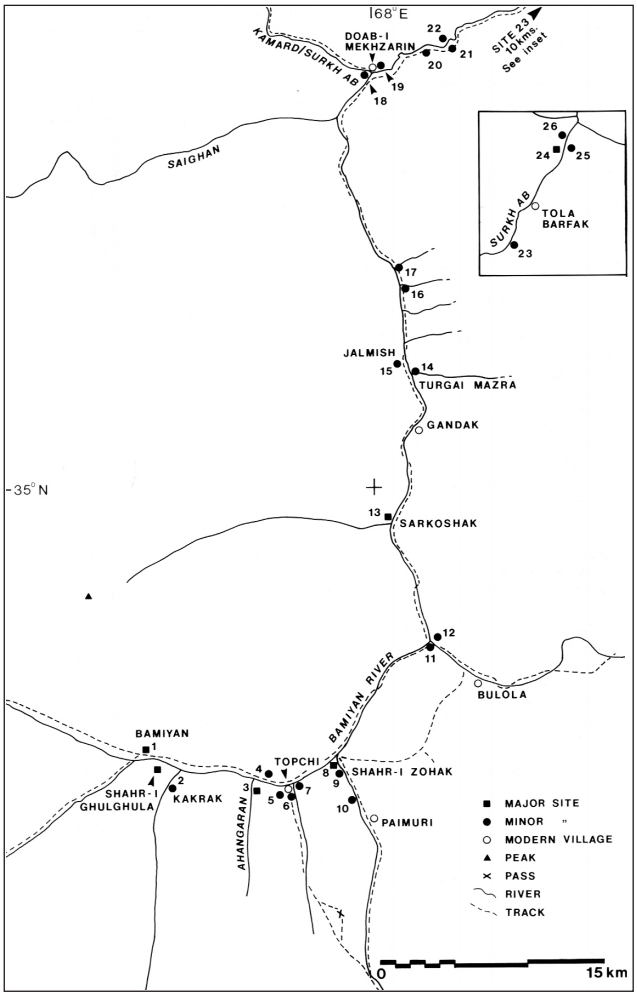


Figure 3.8 *The Bamiyan basin. From Baker and Allchin 1996: map 3.*

Notwithstanding the still unknown aspects of the region's political landscape during the mid-first millennium CE, it is evident that the rise in Bamiyan's fortunes coincided with the rise of the Western Turks in Tukharistan (Bamiyan and northward). We saw that, during the early centuries CE, Bamiyan had served as only a middling way station when small Buddhist monasteries facilitated and benefited from the trickle of commercial and other traffic. By *c.* 600 CE, however, Western Turk interventions had transformed the Bamiyan basin into a cosmopolitan but largely *Buddhist* commercial powerhouse, most vividly attested by its magnificent